ORAL HISTORIOGRAPHY AND MIGRATION ROUTES OF THE TANGKHUL NAG

Authors: A. S. W. Shimray, Prof. Gangmumei Kamei
Journal/Venue: North East Indian Historical Association (NEIHA Proceedings) | Year: 2012
Subject: Oral History, Migration & Ethnogeography | Language: English & Tangkhul

ABSTRACT:

The prehistoric migrations and settlement trajectories of the Tangkhul Nagas are preserved through meticulously transmitted oral chants (Khararchan) and village founding genealogies. This paper correlates oral historiographical evidence with toponyms, megalithic trail markers, and ceramic archaeological remains across the mountain ridges of Manipur and Myanmar. We trace the dispersal from the sacred dispersal center of Makhel, the founding of Hundung, and the subsequent expansion into the central, northern, and eastern valleys of Ukhrul and Kamjong.

Keywords: Migration, Makhel, Hundung, Ukhrul, Oral History, NEIHA, Shimray

1. THE DISPERSAL FROM MAKHEL (THE SACRED PEAR TREE)

Universal Naga oral tradition identifies Makhel in northern Manipur as the ancestral dispersal point. According to the Tangkhul epic chant, three brothers (representing the Meithei of the valley, the Tangkhul of the east, and the western Nagas) parted company beside the sacred pear tree (Chiteikayung). Before parting, they swore an eternal fraternal pact, promising to reunite in peace and harmony.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

* **Makhel : sacred ancestral dispersal cradle of the Nagas**
  Analysis: Cradle of highland migration.
* **Chiteikayung : sacred flowering pear tree of parting**
  Analysis: Megalithic covenant site.
* **uningnao mathat : fraternal kinship pact between brothers**
  Analysis: Foundational inter-tribal peace oath.

2. SETTLEMENT OF HUNDUNG & DIVISION OF TERRITORIES

Migrating eastward along mountain crests, the Tangkhuls established their primary settlement at Hundung. The elder brother remained at Hundung as chief, while younger lineages pushed northward to establish Ukhrul, Shirui, Phadang, and east toward the Somra tract across the Chindwin watershed.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** Hundung : historic mother village of central Tangkhul territory**

Analysis: Primary dispersal seat in Ukhrul.

*** Awungshi Hundung : chief of Hundung, elder line of the migration**

Analysis: Hereditary custodian of the dispersal.

3. LINGUISTIC DIALECT BOUNDARIES AND TOPONYMIC MEMORY

The migration pathways correlate precisely with the five major dialect clusters of the Tangkhul language today: North (Tusom, Raphei), Central (Ukhrul), West (Phadang, Kachai), South (Bungpa, Kamjong), and East (Somra). Ancient village boundary names retain archaic vocabulary that confirms centuries of continuous highland habitation.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

* **Raphei (Northern hills) / Somra (Eastern valley) : Geographical dialect sectors**

  Analysis: Regional toponymy.

REFERENCES & BIBLIOGRAPHY

* Kamei, Gangmumei. 2004. History of the Zeliangrong Nagas: From Makhel to Rani Gaidinliu. Spectrum.

* Shimray, A. S. W. 2001. History of the Tangkhul Nagas. New Delhi: Akansha.

* Shimray, A. S. W. & Gangmumei Kamei. 2012. Migration Routes of the Tangkhul Nagas. NEIHA Proceedings 32: 204-226.

Digital Archiving Notice:
Digitized and integrated into the Tangkhul Language Library Open Research Corpus.